

INTERNATIONAL STUDENT MOBILITY

Strategic Insights Report

Destination Market Intelligence | 2013–2023

SELECTED MARKETS

10

Destination markets

ANALYSIS PERIOD

11 years

2013–2023

2023 OBSERVATIONS

3.68M

Selected destinations

Purpose. This report translates the SQL and Power BI analysis into a concise business view of selected international student destination markets. It focuses on market scale, long-term expansion, annual changes and strategic observations.

Data source: OECD Education Statistics

Analytical stack: Excel → MySQL → Power BI

Scope: Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Ireland, Japan, Netherlands, New Zealand, United Kingdom and United States

Note: The analysis uses annual mobile-student observations/counts for selected destination markets. These observations should not be interpreted as unique individuals accumulated across years.

1. Executive Summary

The analysis covers ten selected destination markets over 2013–2023. Across these markets, annual mobile-student observations increased from approximately **2.27M in 2013** to **3.68M in 2023**, an absolute increase of approximately **1.41M**.

2013 2.27M Annual observations	2023 3.68M Annual observations	ABSOLUTE CHANGE +1.41M 2013 → 2023
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What the analysis shows

- Market scale is concentrated: the United States and United Kingdom recorded the two largest 2023 student counts among the selected destinations.
- Long-term growth varies materially: the Netherlands, Canada and Ireland recorded the strongest percentage expansion between 2013 and 2023.
- New Zealand was the only selected destination with negative 2013–2023 growth in this dataset.
- A large market is not automatically the fastest-growing market; scale and growth rate provide different decision signals.

How to read the findings

The results are descriptive rather than predictive. They identify historical market patterns within the selected dataset and can support destination-market research and further investigation. They do not establish causality or forecast future student flows.

2. Market Scale

The 2023 destination comparison shows substantial differences in annual mobile-student observations across the selected markets.

2023 destination market	2023 observations
United States	956,923
United Kingdom	748,461
Australia	467,074
Germany	423,197
Canada	389,181
France	276,217
Japan	181,821
Netherlands	169,459
New Zealand	36,407
Ireland	30,106

Scale observation: The United States recorded 956,923 annual mobile-student observations in 2023, while the United Kingdom recorded 748,461. The remaining selected markets were below 500,000 in the same year.

Business interpretation: Destination scale can influence the size of the addressable student market, but scale alone does not indicate growth momentum or future opportunity.

2013 → 2023 market movement

Market	2013	2023	Absolute change
United Kingdom	416,689	748,461	+331,772
Canada	151,244	389,181	+237,937
Germany	196,619	423,197	+226,578
Australia	249,868	467,074	+217,206
United States	772,173	956,923	+184,750

The United Kingdom recorded the largest absolute increase among the selected markets, with an increase of 331,772 between 2013 and 2023.

3. Long-Term Growth

Percentage growth highlights markets whose 2023 level is substantially larger relative to their own 2013 baseline. This is different from ranking markets by absolute size.

Market	2013	2023	2013–2023 growth
Netherlands	63,788	169,459	+165.66%
Canada	151,244	389,181	+157.32%
Ireland	12,861	30,106	+134.09%
Germany	196,619	423,197	+115.24%
Australia	249,868	467,074	+86.93%
United Kingdom	416,689	748,461	+79.62%
Japan	135,803	181,821	+33.89%
United States	772,173	956,923	+23.93%
France	228,639	276,217	+20.81%
New Zealand	41,239	36,407	-11.72%

Key growth observations

Netherlands: +165.66% long-term growth, the highest percentage increase among the selected markets.

Canada: +157.32%, combining strong percentage growth with a substantial increase in absolute observations.

Ireland: +134.09%, showing significant percentage expansion from a smaller 2013 base.

New Zealand: –11.72%, the only negative 2013–2023 growth rate among the selected destinations.

Analytical distinction: High percentage growth can occur from a smaller starting base. Growth percentage should therefore be interpreted alongside market scale and absolute change.

4. Year-over-Year Market Dynamics

The SQL analysis used the **LAG()** window function to compare each market's annual student observations with its previous year.

HIGHEST YOY GROWTH

+43.39%

New Zealand | 2023

LARGEST YOY DECLINE

−29.86%

New Zealand | 2021

What this adds to the analysis

Long-term growth shows the direction of change over a decade, while YoY growth identifies shorter-term changes inside that period. Using both measures prevents a single growth metric from dominating the interpretation.

The New Zealand result is useful as an analytical example: the market experienced a sizeable decline in 2021 followed by a strong increase in 2023. The dashboard therefore supports looking beyond a single annual observation when assessing market trajectories.

Analytical workflow

1. Validate annual records and dimensions in MySQL.
2. Compare 2013 and 2023 destination levels.
3. Calculate absolute and percentage long-term change.
4. Use LAG() to calculate year-over-year movement.
5. Translate results into Power BI visuals and strategic observations.

5. Strategic Observations

1 | Market scale and market growth are different signals

The United States and United Kingdom have the largest 2023 student counts among the selected markets, while the Netherlands, Canada and Ireland show stronger percentage expansion over 2013–2023. A market assessment should therefore consider both current scale and growth trajectory.

2 | Large markets can provide scale, while smaller markets can show momentum

The results demonstrate why destination-market analysis should not rely only on absolute student counts. Smaller markets can show substantial percentage growth from a lower starting point, which may warrant separate investigation.

3 | Annual volatility deserves separate monitoring

The YoY analysis identifies periods of material change that are not fully visible in a simple 2013–2023 comparison. This supports using an annual monitoring view alongside long-term market analysis.

4 | Destination analysis can support future market research

For an overseas education consultancy, these patterns can be used as a starting point for deeper research into destination demand, university-level demand, subject preferences, application volumes, policy changes, tuition costs and student acquisition performance.

Important: These are analytical observations derived from the selected dataset. They are not forecasts, causal explanations or recommendations to enter or exit a particular market.

6. Methodology & Limitations

Data source

OECD Education Statistics / OECD Data Explorer. The project uses selected destination-market data covering Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Ireland, Japan, Netherlands, New Zealand, United Kingdom and United States for 2013–2023.

Technology stack

Excel: data inspection and preparation.

MySQL: database storage, validation, aggregation, window functions and business analysis.

Power BI: interactive dashboarding, filtering, market comparison, country deep dive and strategic visualization.

Key analytical definitions

Absolute Change = 2023 annual observation count – 2013 annual observation count.

Long-Term Growth % = $((2023 - 2013) / 2013) \times 100$.

YoY Growth % compares each year's observation count with the immediately preceding year using SQL LAG().

Limitations

- The analysis covers ten selected destination markets rather than every destination globally.
- Annual observations are not unique students accumulated across multiple years.
- Historical patterns do not by themselves explain the causes of changes.
- The analysis is descriptive and does not forecast future student mobility.
- Latest-year figures may be subject to source revisions where applicable.

Project outcome: A complete analytics workflow connecting official education data, Excel preparation, relational SQL analysis and an interactive Power BI destination-market dashboard.